



PMPs

Portable Multimedia Players (PMPs) are the new rage and its become rather fashionable to be seen with a set of earplugs stuck in your ears and a PMP clipped on to your belt. As with any personal technology gadgets, PMPs are geared towards becoming more usable and user-friendly from touch screens to PIM (Personal Information Management) features, to the ability to surf the Internet. Modern-day PMPs are highly converged devices. For a PMP to have mass appeal, it's necessary to include a whole mess of features that will satisfy more often than not.

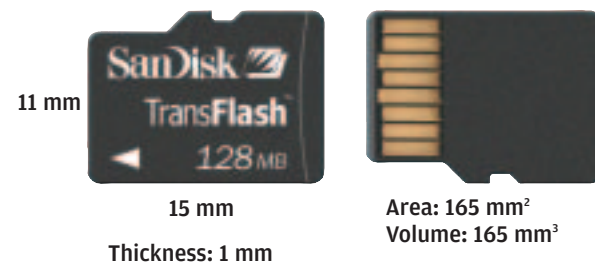
When considering a PMP, it's very necessary to consider your needs. Although this bit of advice may seem at loggerheads with what is mentioned above remember that even the most multi-faceted PMP is aimed at a particular cadre of users more than others. For example, PMPs with larger screens are aimed at people looking for a video player. Such a PMP will compromise on compactness more often than not due to the larger screen. A small PMP would be aimed at someone looking to use it for music, where screen-size is not a criteria, but compactness is. Similarly, a HDD-based PMP would offer more storage than a flash based PMP. Naturally, this is for those whose storage needs are greater.



Storage

In case you just need something to carry around some 200-odd MP3s, a PMP with 2 GB of storage would be enough for you. There's no sense spending more money on a bigger capacity PMP, and you would be better off spending the extra cash for more features or on a better brand. If you want a video-based PMP, you will obviously need more storage as each movie could take up at least 200 MB. Then there are those who like to cart around their entire MP3 collection. Obviously, you would need a lot of space in order to accomplish this.

Memory Expansion



11 mm

15 mm

Thickness: 1 mm

Area: 165 mm²Volume: 165 mm³

Flash

Flash PMPs are available in capacities of up to 32 GB. Generally, the thumb rule is to take into account the total space you need, and search for a PMP offering you exactly double the capacity. 8 GB and 16 GB capacities are the most common and offer the best bang for your buck.



HDD Storage

The 1.8-inch HDD form factor offers a lot of storage to the tune of 80 GB. Good for those with larger storage needs.

Miscellaneous Features

A few PMPs come with additional goodies like in-built WiFi and Bluetooth. An integrated browser coupled with WLAN capabilities means you can surf the net on your PMP; a nifty addition that may be useless to some but ultra-utilitarian for others.

Bluetooth support means music can be transferred wirelessly from a notebook PC or a Bluetooth enabled desktop PC. Bluetooth with support for A2DP means you can actually invest in a set of Bluetooth headphones and enjoy audio content without the need for wired earphones.



Bluetooth headphones

These are becoming quite common. Because its a one-to-one connection there is hardly any disturbance



Bluetooth logo/icon

Useful if you have headphones that support Bluetooth or for transferring music



WLAN logo/icon

WLAN is useful for those looking at surfing the internet on their PMPs

Dimensions

In case you need something unobtrusive that sits in your pocket with minimum fuss, look at something lightweight and really compact. Often, such PMPs will be flash based.

If you're more interested in features like video playback and a touchscreen, then your PMP will also be bulkier and heavier.



A tiny PMP

Earphones

This is an important consideration for a PMP that is typically overlooked. The audio quality of a PMP will largely depend on your choice of earphone. Usually the quality of the earplugs bundled with the PMPs is substandard so you're better off buying a good set of earphones. Earphones can be of two types: In-ear canal earphones that are also called earplugs and in-ear earphones that do not protrude into your ear canal called earbuds.

In general earplugs offer more sound quality than earbuds and they also isolate outside noise better. Due to the fact that they stick into your ear canal they're also tougher to dislodge; which is helpful for joggers, commuters aboard busy public transport and other similar scenarios.

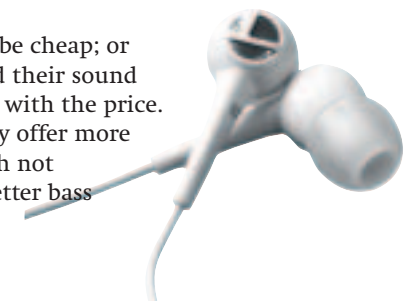


Earbuds

These come with many players. They generally offer strictly decent sound

Earplugs

Earplugs can be cheap; or expensive and their sound quality varies with the price. They generally offer more bass; although not necessarily better bass



Supraaural headphones

These sit on the outer ear. They offer good sound although this differs from brand to brand. Sennheiser and Grado are known for their supra-aural sets